



SmakJit

NGO & Volunteer Hub

SmakJit

Connect NGOs and Volunteers

Course: Human-Computer Interaction

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1. Introduction & Target Users

SmakJit connects people who want to volunteer with organizations that need help running community, education, environmental, and health-related initiatives. The design must serve distinct groups whose goals, technical comfort, and contexts of use differ significantly.

1.1 Problem Area

Difficulty of finding volunteer opportunities for university students (first-year / second-year) who want to gain experience (e.g. CADT students)

1.2 Stakeholder Mapping

- Primary User: University students
- Secondary User: Other students
- Direct Stakeholders: Organizations, Volunteers
- Indirect Stakeholders: Universities, Faculties
- Support Actors: Sponsors, volunteer programs
- Decision-makers/Influencers: Admin websites, volunteer program manager

1.3 Target User Groups

Target User Group	Description & Key Needs
Volunteers	Students, working professionals, and community members who want to contribute time to a cause they care about. Need to: quickly find relevant opportunities, understand requirements, apply with minimal friction, track application status.
Organization Admins	Staff at NGOs, schools, or community groups who need help running events or ongoing programs. Need to: post opportunities easily, describe requirements clearly, review and manage applicants efficiently.

2. UX Research

To validate assumptions about volunteer and organization needs, the team conducted a round of user research combining task analysis, stakeholder mapping, and a mini research plan before beginning interface design (Week 2: Users, Tasks, and Context).

2.1 Task Analysis

★ Users

- Administrators
- Volunteer Program Managers (Organizations)
- Volunteers

★ Goals

- Administrator: ensure platform integrity by managing users and organizations
- Organization: recruit suitable volunteers for program opportunities

- Volunteer: discover and apply for volunteer opportunities to gain practical experience

★ Tasks

- Administrator: review and manage user accounts, monitor and moderate volunteer opportunity listings
- Organization: publish volunteer opportunities, manage incoming applications, and update stage of progress of each application
- Volunteer: search for available opportunities and submit applications

★ Steps

- Administrators: Login as admin -> review organization requests (approve/reject) -> review user accounts and can remove, suspend accounts
- Organizations: Register -> wait for approval from admin -> post opportunities -> check applicants -> mark stage of progress (e.g. received, reviewed, interviewed)
- Volunteers: Register -> Browse to find opportunities -> Apply/Saved for later -> Checked applications in profile to check the status (e.g. received, reviewed)

2.2 Context of Use

- Most volunteers are students who rely primarily on Telegram, Facebook, and Instagram as their main sources of information
- Many first- and second-year students lack a formal CV or prior experience, making them hesitant to submit applications
- Volunteer opportunities are predominantly shared through informal group chats or word-of-mouth, resulting in inconsistent reach and visibility
- Organizations typically manage applications manually via messaging platforms, leading to inefficiencies in tracking and communication

2.3 Mini User Research Plan

- **Who?:** 1st-year and 2nd-year students who need to find volunteer programs
- **What we want to observe:**
 - How students currently find volunteer opportunities
 - What stops them from applying (barriers: confidence, information, trust, time)
 - What information they need before deciding to apply
 - How organizations currently recruit student volunteers and what frustrates them
- **Method**
 - 2-3 semi-structure interview with my class mates
 - 1-2 semi-structure interview with student outside school
- **Interview Prompts**
 - Have you ever volunteered before? How did you find out about it?
 - Where do you usually look when you want to join something new, such as events, clubs, and opportunities?
 - Have you ever wanted to volunteer but didn't follow through? What stopped you?
 - What information would you need to see before applying such as the organization, the role, and the time commitment?
 - Have you ever applied for something and never heard back? How did that feel?

2.4 Initial Problem Statement

Freshman and sophomore students in Cambodia struggle to find legitimate volunteer programs because information is scattered across multiple platforms, causing them to miss chances of applying for opportunities.

2.5 Key Insight

Students want to volunteer, but the current system fails them twice: once when they can't find opportunities, and again when the experience leaves no trace. A platform that solves both discovery and verification would help both sides have better communication.

3. Persona

3.1 Empathy Map

Says	"I can't find active opportunities."
Thinks	"I may lack enough experience."
Does	Searches Telegram, asks friends, browses online
Feels	Anxious, discouraged, and unsure where to start
Pain Points	Anxious, discouraged, and unsure where to start
Needs	One trusted platform with clear information

3.2 Persona: Rith Hengvannarath

Field	Details
Age	18
Year & Major	1st year, Cybersecurity
Main goal	To gain experience through real-world workplace exposure
Context	A 2nd-year cybersecurity student seeking volunteer opportunities. She relies on social media, word of mouth, and asking friends.

Field	Details
Key frustrations	Couldn't find opportunities that match her availability and her major

3.3 User Journey Map

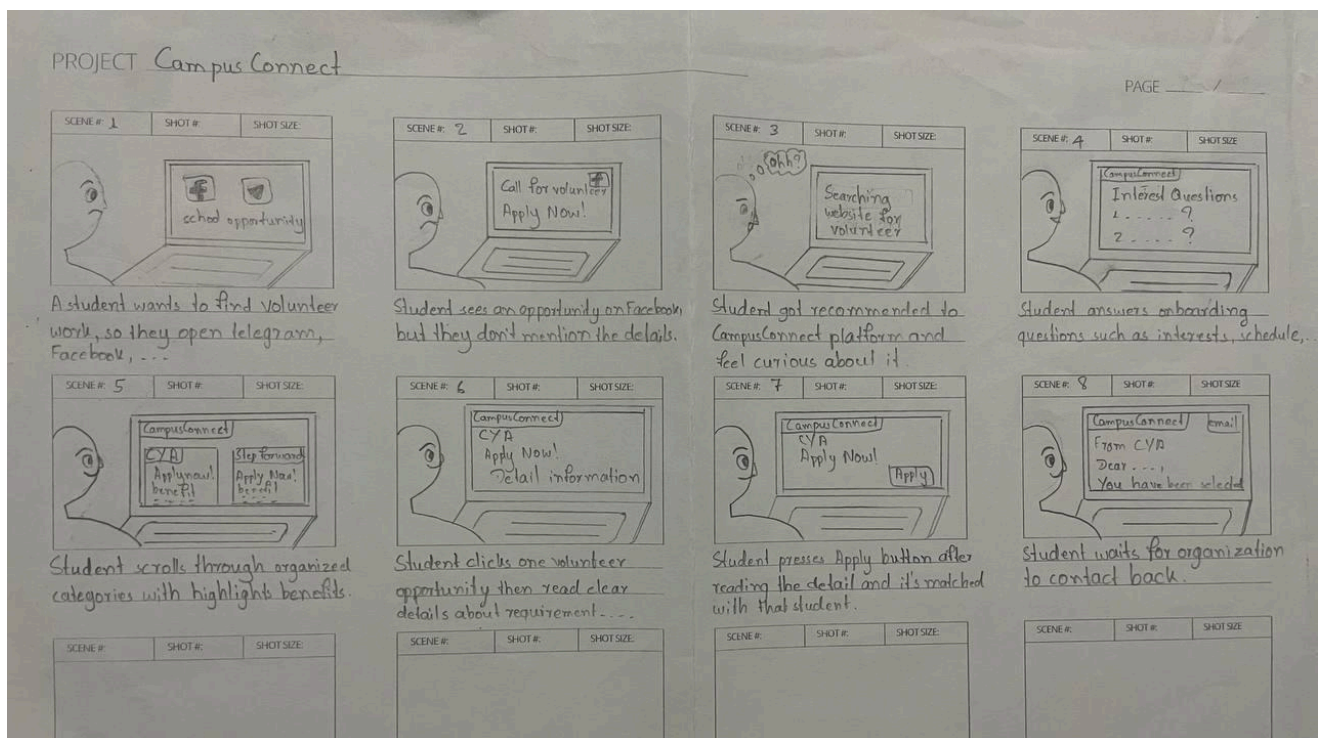
Stage	What the user does	Thoughts/ Feelings	Pain Point	Opportunity
Searching opportunity	Scrolling on Telegram	"I want to find at least one opportunity."	Doesn't know which opportunity to apply for	Provide clearer information (not just scattered posts)
Review requirements	Reads description	"Am I a fit for this opportunity?"	Feels unsure and doubts herself	Clearly display key requirements
Apply	Writes email, sends CV	"Will they contact me for an interview?"	Not sure if the application was reviewed	Simplify the application system

4. Ideation

4.1 How Might We Questions

- ★ How might we make it easier for students to find volunteer opportunities without using multiple platforms?
- ★ How might we make a platform that connects students and organizations feel like going window shopping?
- ★ How might we make students feel curious/excited while browsing opportunities posted by organizations?

5. Storyboarding & Design Critique

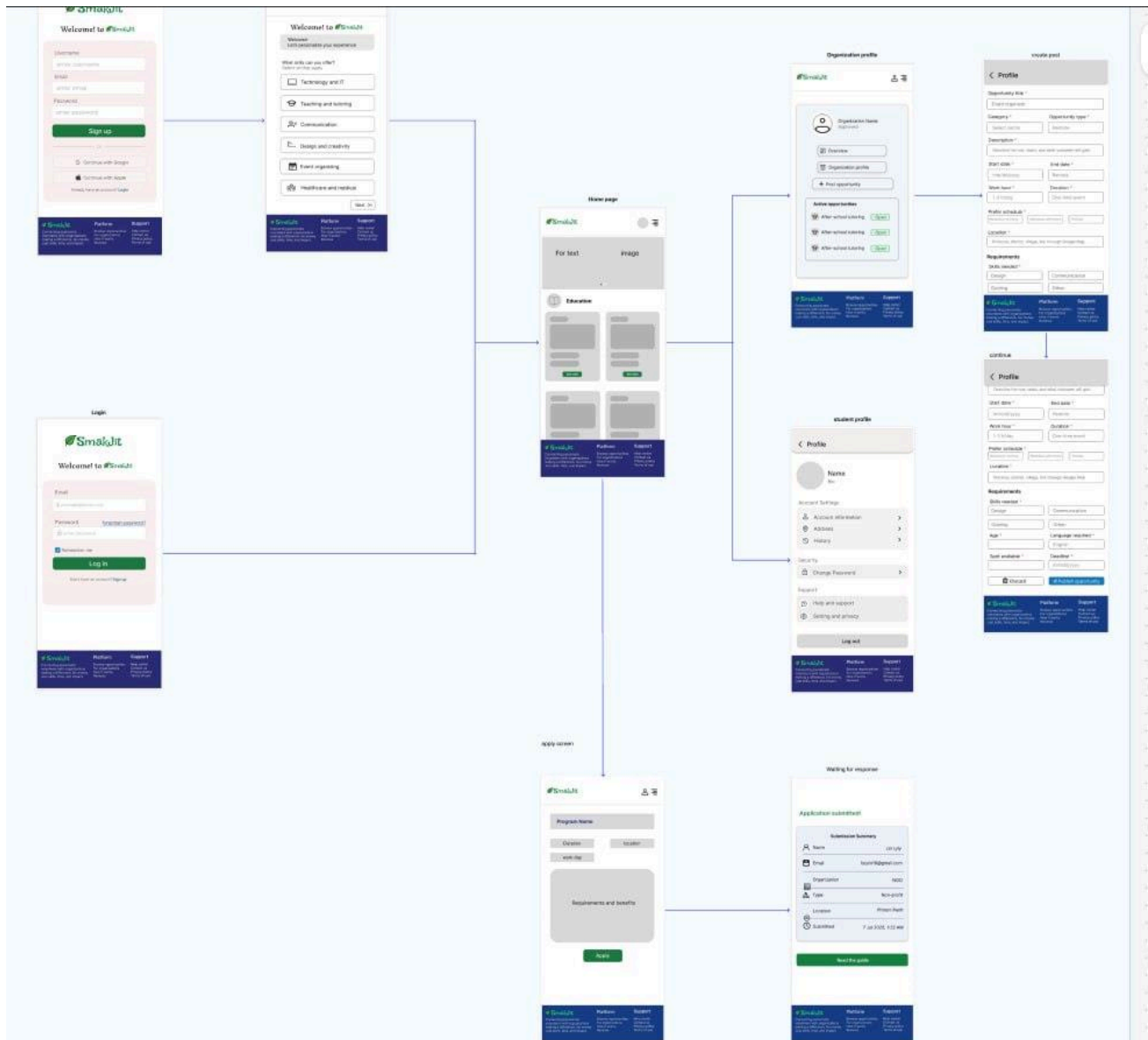


5.1 Peer Critique

What feedback mattered most?	How we define the opportunity organization's role.
What did we revise?	Originally, students were the only intended users, with admins deciding what to post. After critique, the team changed course: organizations became users too, and post opportunities themselves rather than going through an admin.
What stayed the same?	The survey/preferences screen was kept unchanged.

6. Prototyping & Information Architecture

6.1 Wireframes



7. Usability & Consistency Principles Applied

Principle	How it is applied in SmakJit
Visibility of system status	Application status (pending/accepted/rejected) is always visible, loading and confirmation states are shown after key actions like applying or saving.
User control and freedom	Volunteers can withdraw a saved opportunity or edit their profile at any time; clear "Back" navigation is available from detail pages.
Consistency and standards	Card layout, button styles, and category tags are reused identically across the browse, detail, and profile screens.
Error prevention	The Apply button is disabled or hidden if the volunteer does not meet stated requirements, preventing invalid submissions.
Recognition rather than recall	Filters and previously viewed categories remain visible rather than requiring the user to remember and re-type search terms.
Aesthetic and minimalist design	Each opportunity card shows only the essential information (title, organization, category, dates) with further detail one tap away.

8. Usability Testing and Evaluation

8.1 Peer Testing: Findings

★ Heuristic issues

- Error prevention: the sign-up email field accepted any string containing "@" and "." as valid, risking silent bad data at registration.
- Aesthetic & minimalist design: the event detail page had large empty space and low-contrast text, making key details harder to scan.

★ Task Flow Issues

- "Apply" button was ambiguous, unclear if it opened details or submitted immediately, risking hesitation to explore.
- Post-submission navigation was broken, "View My Applications" redirected to the profile page instead of the applications list, making users think their submission failed.

8.2 Design Improvements

- Redirect "View My Applications" straight to the applications list, not the account/profile page
- Tighten email validation on sign-up beyond checking for "@" and "." to prevent malformed addresses.
- Increase contrast and reduce empty space on the event detail page so key requirements are easier to scan at a glance.
- Added one more feature (progress tracking application)

9. Iteration and Reflection

9.1 Summary Ideations

- Week 5 (peer critique): organizations changed from admin-managed listings to posting opportunities themselves (existing content).
- Week 8 (usability testing): the four design actions above, most notably fixing the post-application navigation dead-end and fix the too much white space
- Add more features

9.2 Team Reflection

Throughout this project, our team learned that good design starts with understanding users rather than relying on our own assumptions. Conducting user research helped us better understand the challenges volunteers and organizations face, which guided many of our design decisions.

As we moved from design to testing, we realized that features we thought were clear were not always obvious to other users. Feedback from peer critique and usability testing helped us identify areas for improvement, such as clearer navigation and better visibility of important features.

Overall, this project showed us the importance of continuous user feedback and teamwork. If we were to do this project again, we would involve users earlier and test more frequently so that usability issues could be identified and improved throughout the design process.